

Music and Emotion Experiment Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • The Arts • 20-30 min

Category	The Arts	Time	20-30 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	music-and-emotion-experiment

Big idea: Form shapes perception and feeling.

Overview

Students explore how artistic form shapes perception and emotion.

Student Prompt

Inspect Music and Emotion Experiment Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Music and Emotion Experiment Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: The same image or scene paired with different soundtracks. Describe what you see or hear first, then add title/context and revise the interpretation.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Music and Emotion Experiment Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Emotion rating cards before and after the music changes. Describe what you see or hear first, then add title/context and revise the interpretation.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Music and Emotion Experiment Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A discussion of whether emotion reveals knowledge or distorts it. Describe what you see or hear first, then add title/context and revise the interpretation.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Form shapes perception and feeling.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Music and Emotion Experiment Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Music and Emotion Experiment Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	Can emotion be a source of knowledge?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how form shapes perception and feeling.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: The same image or scene paired with different soundtracks.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- The same image or scene paired with different soundtracks.
- Emotion rating cards before and after the music changes.
- A discussion of whether emotion reveals knowledge or distorts it.

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Play the silent clip with Soundtrack A. Students write what they think is happening.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	Repeat with Soundtracks B and C.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	Students compare changes in perceived story, character and mood.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	Discuss whether music reveals or manipulates meaning.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may treat interpretation as purely subjective and therefore beyond evidence.
- Students may ignore how context, form, and audience knowledge constrain readings.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Supports interpretation with formal features, context, and audience response.
- Explains why multiple readings are not automatically equal.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Short lesson: use only the first example, one response grid, and one debrief question.
- Long lesson: add a second round where students revise the method and compare outcomes.
- Low-tech option: run with printed cards, sticky notes, and a board tally.

Extension Tasks

- Design a second version of the activity that tests the same knowledge issue in another AOK.
- Find a real-world example where the same knowledge problem matters outside the classroom.
- Write a 150-word TOK exhibition-style commentary using the activity as the object context.

Related Activities

- Title Changes Meaning
- Fake or Masterpiece?
- One Image, Many Readings